3RD WAVE VS. 2ND WAVE

Daily average of 150,000 new infections. That's already 29 per cent of the cases during the peak of the second wave

An 18-fold increase in new cases since Jan. 6, a transmission faster than that in the second wave

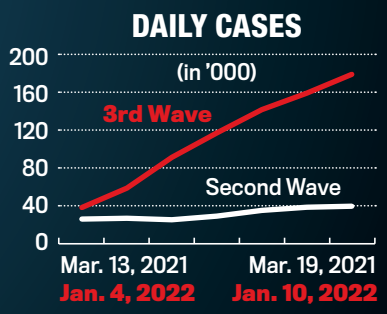
On average, each coronavirus patient is infecting 2.69 others. The highest R-value in the second wave was 1.22

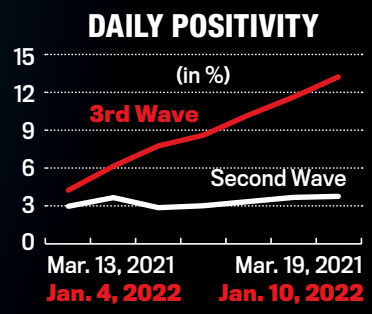
5-10% hospitalisation compared to 20-23% in second wave

Weekly growth in fresh cases and positivity is already faster than at the start of the second wave



ANI





Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

dicator is the positivity rate, or the number of people testing Covid positive out of 100. At 13.29 per cent on January 10 in India, the figure was more than double the WHO-recommended containment threshold of 5 per cent.

Elsewhere in the world, too, Omicron's spread has been more rapid than Delta's. A University of Hong Kong study suggests that Omicron is up to 70 times more transmissible than its Delta counterpart. (The study is yet to be peer-reviewed). Another study, published on the medRxiv site and also awaiting peer review, analysed 131,478 tests in France from October 25 to December 18, 2021, and found Omicron 105 per cent more contagious. In the US, analysis by experts at the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), has shown that Omicron accounted for over half of all the new cases in a little more than a month's time since the strain was first detected. "There are specific mutations in the spike protein that make it easier for the virus to enter human cells," explains Dr Rakesh Mishra, director of the Tata Institute of Genetics and Society in Bengaluru. Reports from the UK, the country with the greatest number of Omicron cases, show that its peak figure of new cases was four times that seen with the Delta variant.

Studies across the world also show Omicron to have a shorter incubation period—the time taken for symptoms to appear after infection—again highlighting its more infectious nature over other variants. The Alpha variant had an incubation period of six days and Delta four days. For Omicron, the average is three days. The CDC has observed that Omicron patients are the most infectious in the first two days before the symptoms manifest and continue to be so for three days after. In more than 100 studies from 17 countries, it suggested, most transmission seemed to take place early in an infection. "It is critical to get tested as soon as symptoms appear as this is the time when a person is also most likely to infect others," says Dr Sandeep Budhiraja, the medical director of Max Super Speciality Hospitals, Saket, in Delhi.

WHO IS MOST VULNERABLE TO OMICRON?

Omicron seems to spare no age group, with both the young and old getting equally afflicted. Nor does it care for those who have been fully vaccinated or even infected with a different variant before. "Omicron is causing a large number of breakthrough infections," says Budhiraja. "There is no guaranteed way to predict who will or won't get infected." In Maharashtra, which has reported the highest number of Omicron cases, around 81 per cent of those infected with the new strain were fully vaccinated. While there is no data in India yet about the ages of those infected, in the US, more than half the Omicron cases were among those between the ages of 18 and 39 years. "Even in the past two waves, we have seen that even if you are young and healthy, it does not mean you cannot turn Covid positive," says Delhi-based infectious diseases specialist Dr Ankita Baidya.

In the pattern of its spread across the country, too, Omicron differs from the way Alpha (first wave) and Delta (second wave) progressed. While in the first two waves, infec-